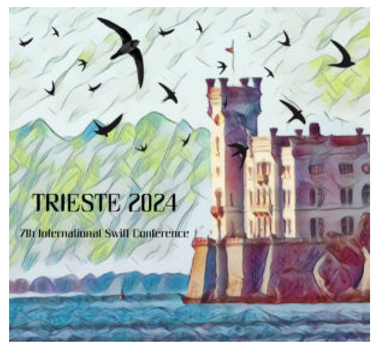
SWIFT AND SPARROW TOWERS IN THE PROVINCES OF NOVARA AND VARESE: CENSUS AND EVALUATION FOR SWIFTS' CONSERVATION



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ABSTRACT

Man has constructed certain structures made available for nesting to several bird species, including Swifts, dating back to the Middle Ages. Our research has unfolded within the territory of the province of Varese since 2016 and, subsequently, extended to the neighboring province of Novara (starting from 2020). The study area encompasses a surface area of over 2500 km², inhabited by more than 1.2 million people in over 200 municipalities.
The existing structures have been surveyed, photographed and catalogued along with the collection of pertinent information to assess their potential restoration and/or rehabilitation for conservation purposes, particularly for Swifts which, due to renovation interventions or the construction of new artefacts, experience diminishing nesting opportunities, especially in urban settings.
As is well documented, these structures allowed humans to supplement their diet with animal protein, otherwise not easily obtainable (Ferri, 2018), to the extent of assuming a function akin to actual "hunting harvest", therefore subjected to specific taxation during the 20th century (Chigi della Rovere et al., 1933). The surveyed structures were typically intended for synanthropic species, particularly sparrows and starlings, often drawn by human activities such as poultry farming and the resultant availability of grains; at times, these species were even raised by humans, as in the case of Columbiformes.
Several study and research projects are already underway at some of these structures, facilitated by the cooperation of the owners (whether public or private).

MATERIALS AND METHODS

- **Visual satellite research:** For much of the territory under examination, satellite images are available for consultation through Google Earth and Google Maps. This allowed the identification of some typical structures such as elevated square turrets;
- **Historical photographic research:** The presence of bird structures is fairly abundant, as often evidenced from historical photos taken from before the 1960s, This was the period of major economic modification in many urban centres following the economic boom of the 1960s. This was followed by an increase in construction in urban centres. In some cases, the destruction or modification of structures was observed, as they were adapted to new architectural needs. However, it has sometimes been possible to trace the location of such structures that have since disappeared or been hidden by new buildings, by studying place names;
- **Toponym-based research:** Recurring terms such as "colombara", "colombaia" and "torre" have indicated the past presence of bird towers. Consequently, a search for similar toponyms was carried out using the Google Maps search engine;
- **Opportunistic reports:** Many structures have been identified during various journeys, in the territories of two provinces.

RESULTS

The under study area comprised of the provinces of Varese and Novara (total area 2,538 km²), with approximately 1.24 million inhabitants (density 489 inhabitants/km²). As of March 31, 2024, 244 structures have been included in the census: 173 were built for nesting sparrows or swifts, 44 for pigeons, and 27 for all three species (Table 1). 136 of the structures are walls, 107 are towers, and 1 is a mixed structure (Table 2).
The buildings were found in 103 municipalities out of the total 224 in the two provinces (46%). Some examples are illustrated in the pictures below (Pictures 1-6).
In some of the structures, projects for the study and conservation of Common Swift (*Apus apus*) have been initiated.

Table 1

	Intended use	
	n	%
Sparrow	173	70.90%
Pigeon	44	18.03%
Mixed	27	11.07%
Tot	244	100.00%

Table 2

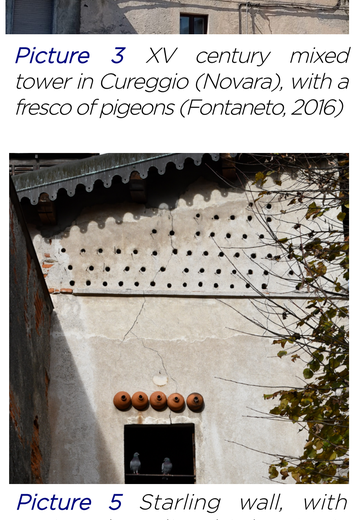
	Construction type	
	n	%
Wall	136	55.74%
Tower	107	43.85%
Mixed	1	0.41%
Tot	244	100.00%

Picture 1 Tipical sparrow tower in Novara

Picture 2 Pigeon tower in Brezzo di Bedero (Varese)

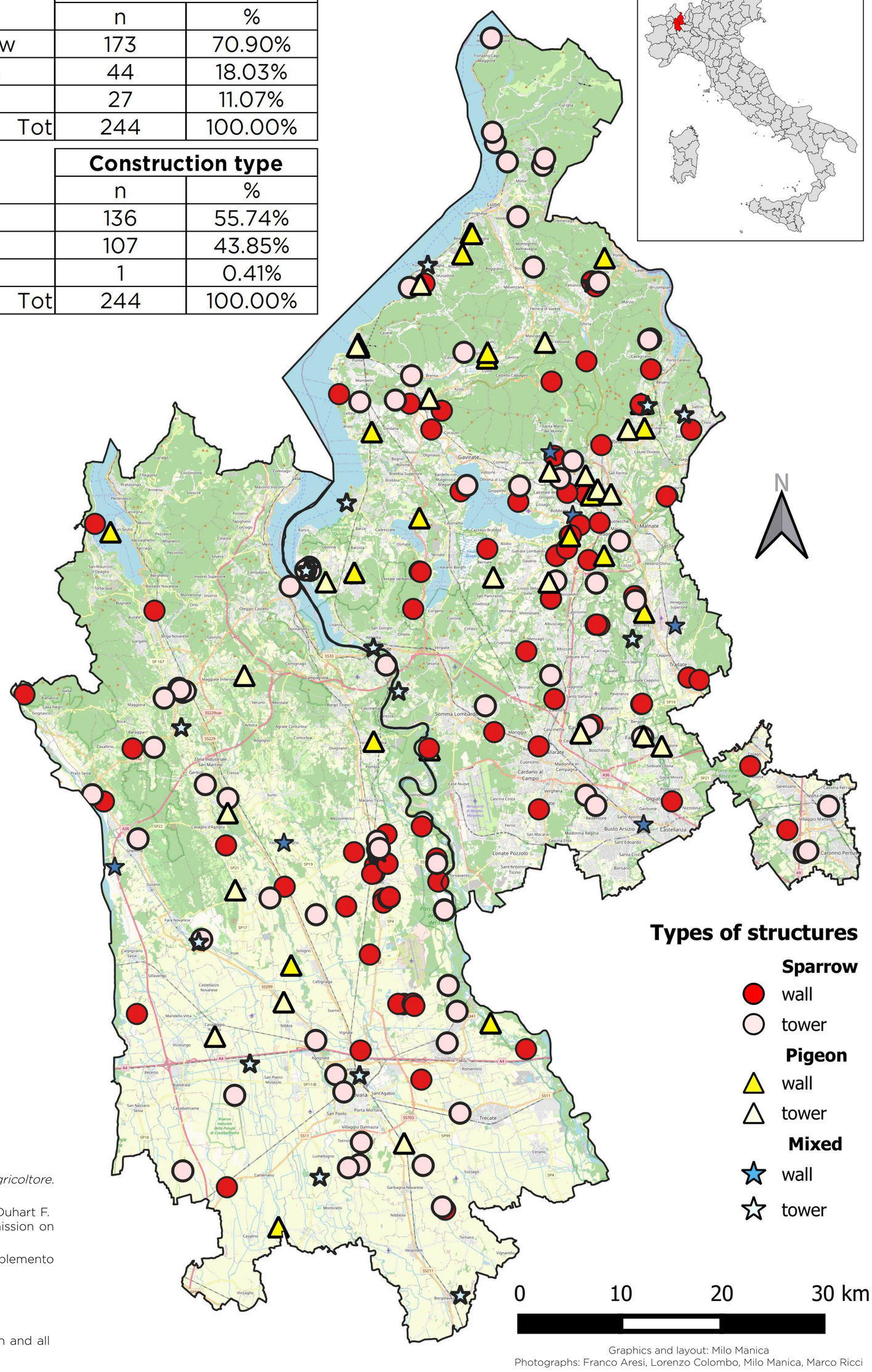
Picture 3 XV century mixed tower in Cureggio (Novara), with a fresco of pigeons (Fontaneto, 2016)

Picture 4 Mixed tower in Ispra (Varese), now used by Common Swifts



Picture 5 Starling wall, with curious breeding bird pots, in Borgomanero (Novara)

Picture 6 Sparrow wall in Azzate (Varese), now used by Common Swifts



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